Ras Agez
Bi annual Newsletter of CoSAP
January – March 2026 issue No.23 (Vol.XI)

Message from the Secretariat

Dear Readers,

We are extremely pleased to share with you issue No. 24 "Ras Agez" newsletter covering January to March 2026. Please forward your comments, suggestions and remarks to us at cosap.doc@gmail.com.

Enjoy reading "Ras Agez"

Yosef Akalu
Director CoSAP

CoSAP at Ethiopia Civil Society Week

More than 115 civil society organizations converged on the Addis International Convention Centre for the 5th Ethiopia Civil Society Week Exhibition and CoSAP brought and share one of the most compelling stories in its booth.

The three-day event drew senior government leaders including H.E Adem Farah, H.E Prof. Berhanu Nega Minster of Education, and H.E Dr. Belete Molla Minster of Innovation a signal that Ethiopian policymakers are paying closer attention to what civil society has built. At its exhibition pavilion, CoSAP told a story of scale and depth: 350,000 women across Ethiopia, connected through a grassroots movement that turns collective savings into community transformation.







CoSAP showcased the technologies that are extending the movement's reach: Oral Information Management tools developed with MOVE for women with limited literacy, and digital credit-scoring systems built with COOP Bank and Kifiya Financial Technology that give SHG members access to uncollateralized credit based on their group savings history.

Discussions on the EU CSF+ Program gave CoSAP an opportunity to make the case for localization the idea that development resources directed to organizations deeply embedded in local communities generate returns that international actors cannot replicate. The exhibition was not just a showcase. It was an argument for a different way of doing development. On top of this, 5 CoSAP's sub grantees have got the opportunity promote their works and their organization.

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CoSAP's General Assembly Charts the SHG Movement's National Future

On March 26, 2026, the Consortium of Self Help Group Approach Promoters (CoSAP) convened its Annual General Assembly Meeting at Aya Hotel, marking an important institutional milestone for the consortium and the wider Self Help Group (SHG) movement in Ethiopia. As CoSAP's highest governing platform, the Assembly brought together Board members, executive leaders from member organizations, and presidents of grassroots federations from across the country to review progress, strengthen transparent governance, and set strategic priorities for the year ahead.





Beyond fulfilling governance responsibilities, the General Assembly also served as a platform for strategic reflection and institutional coordination. CoSAP's Board and executive leadership presented narrative and financial reports highlighting key achievements, lessons, and challenges from the past year. Delegates reviewed the continued expansion of the SHG movement, which now reaches more than 350,000 women across Ethiopia, and collectively identified priorities for future growth, sustainability, and impact.

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CoSAP Marks International Women's Day Through Celebration and Advocacy

CoSAP marked International Women's Day through two important engagements that highlighted both the power of collective celebration and the importance of women's leadership in shaping inclusive systems. In collaboration with Saved to Save (S2S), CoSAP celebrated March 8 with federation members at Aya Hotel in Addis Ababa under the theme "Give to Gain." The event created space for reflection, shared learning, and renewed commitment to advancing women's empowerment through collective action and the Self-Help Group (SHG) approach. The celebration reinforced a core message of the movement: when women are supported with opportunities, skills, and resources, the impact extends far beyond individuals to strengthen families, communities, and the wider economy.











CoSAP also joined FSD Ethiopia's International Women's Day 2026 forum, "Access to Influence: Advancing Women's Digital Financial Inclusion and Leadership," where policymakers, commercial banks, and FinTech leaders came together to discuss the future of inclusive finance in Ethiopia. Drawing on the experiences of 350,000 women engaged in SHGs, CoSAP emphasized that digital financial inclusion must go beyond access to technology and be supported by financial literacy, reliable infrastructure, and strong community support systems. Together, these engagements reflected CoSAP's vision of women not only benefiting from economic systems, but actively shaping and leading them.

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Irish Government Delegation Visits Yetawok Federation and Witnesses Transformation First-hand

On February 17, CoSAP welcomed a high-level Irish Government and philanthropic delegation to the Yetawok Federation in Addis Ababa, marking an important milestone in CoSAP's international engagement efforts and highlighting the growing global recognition of the Self-Help Group (SHG) approach as a sustainable model for inclusive development.

The delegation included Neale Richmond, senior representatives from the Embassy of Ireland, and leadership from Tearfund Ireland, a key strategic partner supporting the expansion of the SHG movement. Their visit provided an opportunity to witness firsthand how community-led structures are transforming the lives of women and strengthening grassroots development.








A major highlight of the visit was the direct dialogue between the delegation and elected leaders of the Yetawok Federation. Federation members shared their experiences openly, presenting achievements in savings, small business growth, and community advocacy. They explained how participation in SHGs has helped women improve household incomes, cope with rising living costs, access credit opportunities, and strengthen their confidence and decision-making power within their families and communities.

The delegation also observed how the federation functions as a wider community support system, helping families during times of crisis while contributing to improved wellbeing, including children's education, nutrition, and healthcare. The visit demonstrated how collective action and peer support can build resilient communities and create lasting social and economic change through locally driven solutions.

The engagement concluded with renewed commitment from Irish development partners and CoSAP to continue strengthening collaboration that places women, local leadership, and community empowerment at the center of sustainable development efforts.

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CoSAP Strengthens Women's Leadership Through Partnerships and Inclusive Finance Engagements

CoSAP strengthened its leadership in women's economic empowerment through strategic partnerships and inclusive digital finance initiatives, reinforcing the growing influence of Ethiopia's Self-Help Group (SHG) movement at national and continental levels. In Addis Ababa, CoSAP signed a Memorandum of Understanding with the Hailemariam and Roman Foundation to scale grassroots women's empowerment initiatives across Ethiopia and beyond. The partnership links CoSAP's network of more than 350,000 SHG women with the Foundation's diplomatic, philanthropic, and Pan-African reach, aiming to strengthen financial inclusion, resource mobilization, and joint advocacy for women's economic leadership and community-driven development.





CoSAP also signed a landmark agreement with MultiChoice Ethiopia (MCE) on February 20, 2026, under its Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiative to support women in SHGs through a revolving loan fund. The pilot program will provide collateral-free loans of up to ETB 30,000 for 40 women in Addis Ababa over six months to one year, alongside financial literacy and entrepreneurship training. By introducing a guarantee-fund-based lending model, the initiative removes traditional collateral barriers and creates a scalable approach to women's economic empowerment, while CoSAP commended MCE for pioneering CSR-driven social impact and encouraged broader private sector engagement.

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Celebrating Legacy and Leadership: CoSAP Honors Founding Member Organizations JeCCDO and YWCA Ethiopia

CoSAP proudly joined two of its founding member organizations, Jerusalem Children and Community Development Organization (JeCCDO) and Young Women's Christian Association in Ethiopia (YWCA Ethiopia), in celebrating major institutional milestones that reflect decades of commitment to community development, women's empowerment, and grassroots leadership in Ethiopia.






At the JeCCDO Training Center in Bishoftu, stakeholders from government institutions, civil society, Self-Help Groups (SHGs), and development partners gathered to mark JeCCDO's 40th anniversary. JeCCDO CEO Mulugeta Gebru reflected on the organization's evolution from a childcare institution into a leader in community-based development. As one of CoSAP's founding pillars, JeCCDO has been instrumental in advancing the SHG approach in Ethiopia, supporting a movement that now reaches over 350,000 women nationwide. Its work was further recognized by Fasikaw Molla, who praised its institutional resilience, transparent governance, and alignment with national development priorities.





CoSAP also participated in the 64th anniversary and 25th reopening celebration of YWCA Ethiopia, another founding member organization with a strong legacy in women's leadership and social development. The event brought together members, partners, government officials, donors, and beneficiaries to reflect on the association's impact. YWCA honored veteran members and young volunteers for their service and recognized partners including CoSAP for continued collaboration. A key highlight was YWCA Ethiopia's announcement of its entry into the Board of the World YWCA, marking a major global milestone. The occasion also allowed CoSAP to reconnect with former YWCA General Secretary Melat, whose leadership was instrumental in the early establishment of the CoSAP network.

Through both events, CoSAP reaffirmed its appreciation for its founding member organizations and their shared commitment to community-driven development, women's empowerment, and grassroots leadership across Ethiopia.

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"Ras Agez" meaning "Self Help"

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